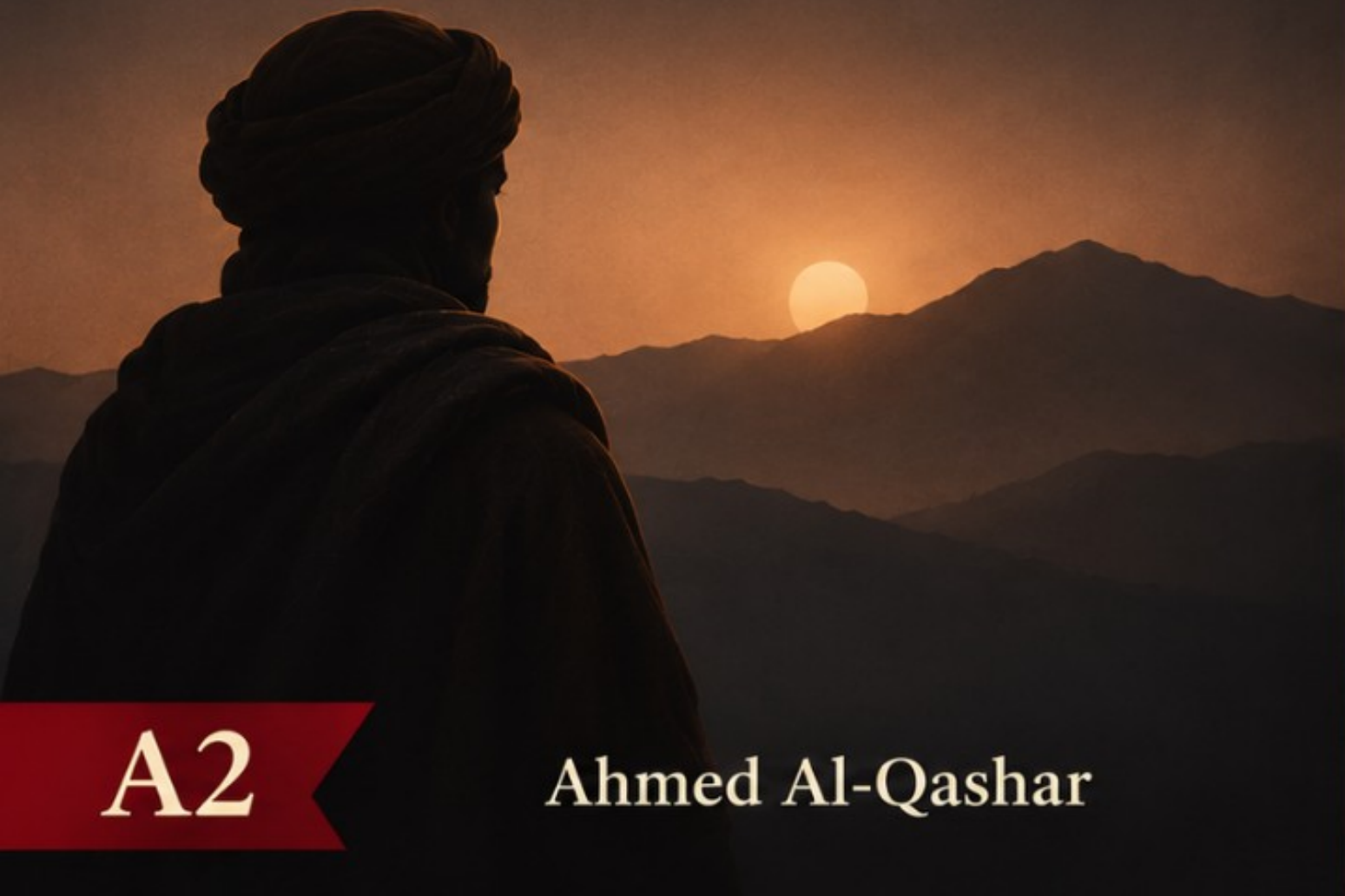
WorldVoice Library

Seven Days Across the Atlas

A Journey in Morocco, 1784



A2

Ahmed Al-Qashar

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Seven Days Across the Atlas

A Journey in Morocco, 1784

Written by

Ahmed Al-Qashar

ENGLISH GRADED READERS

A2 · Elementary

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Read · Learn · Explore

Story Introduction

Seven days. A damaged bridge. A village waiting for help.

Morocco, 1784. Salim is eighteen and works in a map shop in Fez. When a mountain village asks for help, he joins a caravan carrying six sacks of barley, two boxes of warm cloth and a sealed letter. Their journey should take seven days, but heavy rain has changed the roads. The only map of an older path belonged to Salim's father. When the map is damaged, Salim must learn to trust the people who know the mountains.

Along the way, the travellers face a narrow ledge, a storm, a hidden spring and a broken crossing. Each day gives them a new choice. Will they reach Aït Saha with the supplies still safe?

Before You Read

1. What could make a mountain road dangerous after rain?
2. Why might a village need grain and warm cloth?
3. What can a traveller learn from a map? What can a local guide add?

Characters

The people you will meet during the seven days

Salim

An eighteen-year-old assistant mapmaker from Fez. He carries his father's old map and learns that a good mapmaker must listen.

Amina

A careful traveller from the foothills. She notices details, asks good questions and helps people remain calm.

Idris

An experienced mountain guide. He studies weather and ground before choosing a route.

Hassan

The mule keeper. He looks after three pack animals and protects the grain and cloth.

Rachid

A wood carrier familiar with the old mountain path. His sister lives in the village across the hills.

Fatima

A teacher and letter writer in Aït Saha. She requests supplies after the river damages the bridge.

Omar

Salim's uncle in Fez, who organises the supplies and teaches him to make careful records.

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After the story: 40-word Glossary · Reading Comprehension · Short Answers · Think / Speak / Write · Language Practice · Final Test · Answer Key

Read all seven days before doing the activities at the back.

DAY ONE

The Letter from Fez

The city of Fez was waking up. The sun was still low, and the streets were cool. Salim walked past the bread shops with a leather bag under his arm. He was eighteen, and he worked for his uncle, a man who sold paper and copied maps. Salim knew the streets of Fez very well, but he had never travelled far into the mountains.

Every morning Salim opened the shutters of the map shop. He put clean paper on the table and mixed black ink in a little bowl. Most days he copied the names of streets or drew the roads between nearby towns. He liked the careful work. A wrong line on a map could send someone in the wrong direction, so he checked his drawings twice. He had never needed a map to find his way home. This morning was different. The letter under his uncle's hand would take him far beyond the streets he knew.

Omar looked older than usual. He had read the letter several times in the night. "It was written by Fatima, the teacher in Aït Saha," he explained. "The people have enough water, but their grain is almost gone. A flood took away the bridge to the lower valley. No one knows when another caravan can reach them." Salim watched his uncle fold the paper. He had copied many letters for other people, but he had never carried one that mattered so much.

At the shop, his uncle Omar was waiting with a letter. The paper was folded three times, and a little red mark closed it. Omar held it carefully.

"This arrived last night," he said. "It comes from Aït Saha, a village beyond the high hills. The people there need help. The last rain damaged their bridge, and they cannot bring food from the valley."

"Can we send food?" Salim asked.

"We can. Six bags of barley and two boxes of warm cloth are ready. But the road is not simple. The village is seven days away if the weather stays good."

Omar spread a list on the table. Six sacks of barley were written on it, with two boxes of warm cloth below. There was also a small bag of salt and food for the travellers. "I have asked each family in our street to give something," he said. "Some gave grain. Some gave cloth. A woman who has very little gave us her last spare blanket. We must take good care of every bag."

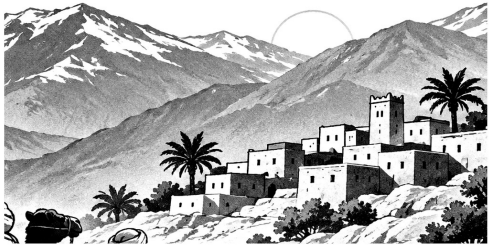
"Why don't you come with us?" Salim asked. Omar smiled. "My knees are not young, and the shop cannot close for a week. More important, this is your chance to use what your father taught you. You will not go alone. Listen to Idris, and write down the places you see. A map is a promise to the next person who reads it." Salim understood the words, but they felt heavier than the paper in his hand.

A woman entered the shop. Her name was Amina, and she came from a village near the Atlas Mountains. She wore a dark wool cloak and carried a walking stick. "I know the road as far as the high pass," she said. "My family used it for many years. I will travel with you."

Behind her stood Idris, an older guide with a grey beard. A mule keeper named Hassan waited outside with three animals. One mule carried food for the travellers. The other two would carry the village supplies.

Hassan brought the animals one by one to the shop door. He knew each mule by the sound of its steps. The smallest was called Noura. She was quick on good roads but disliked loud voices. The strongest was Barak, who would carry two sacks of grain. Hassan showed Salim how to balance a load. A bag that was too heavy on one side could hurt an animal or make it fall on a mountain path.

Amina checked the boxes of cloth. She pulled at the ropes and covered the boxes with thick oiled fabric. "I have seen rain turn a good road into a river," she said. "If the cloth becomes wet, the children will have nothing warm to wear." Idris looked at the sky, then at the travellers. "We leave before the streets become busy," he said. "A long journey begins with a careful first step." Salim put away his best pen, took a short pencil, and closed the shop shutters.



Omar placed a small map in Salim's hands. "Your father drew this when he was young," he said. "He knew a quiet path beside the mountains. There are three small circles on the paper, near a line of water. I have never understood them."

Salim touched the circles. He remembered his father teaching him to read maps at the table. "A map does not tell you everything," his father used to say. "Look at the land and listen to the people."

"Why are we carrying this letter?" Salim asked.

"The people of Aït Saha must know that the supplies are coming," Omar said. "The letter also tells their teacher what our caravan can bring. Keep it dry."

The folded letter was smaller than Salim's hand. He placed it in a dry cloth bag, then put the bag beneath his shirt. He made sure the knot could not open. He had heard stories of letters lost in rivers and carried away by the wind. This one would not leave him easily.

Before they left, Omar gave Salim a blank notebook. On its first page he had written three questions: Where did you stop? Where did you find water? Who helped you? Salim read the questions aloud. "You didn't ask where I found the fastest road," he said. "A fast road is not always a safe road," Omar replied. "And people are part of every road. Do not forget their names." Salim slipped the notebook beside the old map and promised to bring it back filled with useful notes.

At the eastern gate of Fez, Salim looked back. He could see the rooftops and hear the noise of the city. Ahead of him lay hills that became higher and darker in the distance.

"Are you afraid?" Amina asked.

"A little," Salim said. "I have never been away for seven days."

"Then you will learn something new each day," she answered.

They began to walk. Hassan led the first mule. Idris walked beside the last one and checked its load. The road was wide at first, with olive trees on both sides. At noon they stopped near a well and ate bread and dates.

Outside the city, the road passed gardens and small fields. The smell of fresh bread was replaced by the smell of earth and olive leaves. Salim walked beside Amina and asked about her home. She had grown up near the first hills, where her mother taught her to find water by watching the trees. "In a town, you ask for the name of a street," she said. "Here you may ask for the name of a spring. Both questions can save you from being lost."

At the well they met two boys filling clay jars. The boys watched the mules and asked what was in the sacks. "Food for a village beyond the mountains," Salim answered. One boy wanted to know whether the mountains were as high as the clouds. "Higher than these clouds on some days," Idris said, and pointed toward a distant white line. The boys looked at it in silence. Salim saw the mountains as if for the first time. They were beautiful, but they also seemed far away.

That evening they reached a small house where travellers could sleep. The sky was clear, but Idris looked toward the mountains for a long time.

The house belonged to an elderly couple. There was only one large room for guests, so the travellers slept close together on simple mats. The man of the house brought a pot of warm soup. His wife asked about the people in Aït Saha. "My brother once traded cloth there," she said. "It is a small place, but the people share what they have." Salim thought of the woman in Fez who had given a blanket. He began to understand that the caravan carried more than the things tied to the mules.

After supper, Hassan repaired a loose strap by the fire. He let Salim try the knot. Salim pulled the rope and smiled when it held. "Good," Hassan said, "but we check it again in the morning." Amina took out a small needle and fixed a tear in her cloak. Idris drew a line in the dust, showing the first part of tomorrow's climb. Salim copied it into his notebook and wrote the names of their hosts. He wanted to remember this quiet house as clearly as the larger places on his map.

"There will be rain," he said quietly.

"How do you know?" Salim asked.

Idris pointed to the clouds above the highest hills. "The mountains tell us many things. We must listen."

Salim put the letter close to his chest, inside his coat. Day one had been easy, but the hard part of the journey was still ahead.

DAY TWO

The Narrow Road

The second day began before sunrise. A cold wind came from the mountains. Hassan gave each mule a little water and checked the ropes around the bags. Salim helped him, pulling each rope until the load could not move.

While Hassan worked, Salim remembered waking to the sounds of the animals outside. The air felt colder than the day before. Idris was already standing by the door. He had placed a smooth stone beside each bag to show where it should go. "We must pack the same way every morning," he told Salim. "When things have a place, we notice if anything is missing." Salim counted the bags: one, two, three, four, five, six. The two cloth boxes were dry. The letter was still safe against his chest.

They ate bread with a little oil. There was no time for a long breakfast because the road ahead followed a ridge. A ridge was the high line of land between two valleys. Salim wrote the word in his notebook. He had seen it on maps, but he had never stood on one. Amina warned him that the wind could push against a traveller even when the sky looked clear. "Watch the animals," she said. "They often feel a change before we do."

"Do not pull too hard," Hassan said. "A tired animal needs a comfortable load."

The road became narrow after breakfast. There were stones under their feet and steep hills above them. Small farms stood far apart. Amina spoke to an old woman outside one house and bought fresh bread.

"She says the river is high," Amina told the others. "We should reach the old crossing before dark."

The old woman near the farm had walked the mountain roads in her younger days. She wore a long brown cloak and carried bread in a woven basket. Amina asked her about the river. The woman pointed with her stick. "The water has been strange this season," she said. "After the last storm, it rose in the night. People thought they knew the crossing, but the river had moved the stones." She advised them to stay on the higher path until they had news from someone who had seen the river that week.

As they left, the woman gave Salim a small piece of bread. "You look as if you are thinking too much," she said. Salim laughed, but she was right. He was thinking about every line on his father's map. Amina told him to put the paper away and

look at the mountain in front of him. There were three dark bands of rock above the farms. "Now draw what you see," she said. His new drawing looked different from the old map. Both could still be useful.

At midday they came to a part of the road beside a deep valley. Salim could see a stream shining far below. On the other side of the path was a wall of rock. Only one person could walk beside a mule.

Suddenly the youngest mule stopped. Its front foot was close to the edge. A loose stone fell and made a long sound as it went down the hill.

"Do not push it!" Idris called.

Hassan stood quietly beside the animal. He spoke in a low voice and loosened one rope. Amina held the bags while Salim took a step back to give the mule room.

After a minute the animal moved. One careful step became two, and then it passed the narrow part of the path. Everyone was silent until all three mules stood safely on wide ground.



The danger was over, but Salim's hands were shaking. He sat on a flat stone for a moment and looked at the narrow path behind them. It was only a short part of the road. It had seemed as long as the whole morning. Hassan checked Noura's legs and gave her a little water. He did not seem angry with her. "She stopped because she was afraid," he said. "Fear is a warning. We must understand it before we decide what to do."

Idris showed Salim a safe place to stand when an animal passed beside a steep drop. "Never stand below a heavy load," he said. "If it moves, you may not have time to get away." Salim put this advice in his notebook. He also drew the narrow path as two lines with a small stone beside them. A traveller who saw the mark later might choose to carry less weight on that part of the road. He was no longer drawing just for himself.

"I wanted to pull it forward," Salim said.

"That could have made it afraid," Hassan answered. "Sometimes going slowly is the fastest way."

A little later they found a stone shelter with a flat roof. Inside, a shepherd was sitting beside a small fire. His name was Musa. He offered them water and asked where they were going.

"Aït Saha," Idris said.

Musa looked surprised. "The direct road is damaged. The river took part of the bridge last week. There is another path, but it is older. People do not use it often."

Salim opened his father's map. "Is it this one?" he asked.

Musa studied the lines. "Perhaps. I know the three hills here, but I do not know these circles. Ask at the next village. The older people may remember."

Musa had a weathered face and hands that looked strong from years of work. He told them that his father had once taken animals along the old eastern path. "In those days there were little signs made from stones," he said. "They showed people the places where water waited after the dry weeks." He could not remember all the signs. He knew only that his father often spoke about three stones near a river.

Salim's eyes went to the circles on the map. "Could three circles mean three stones?" he asked. Musa lifted his shoulders. "Perhaps. The old roads are full of small memories. A stone means nothing to one person and everything to another." He took a piece of charcoal and drew the shape of the valley on the floor. Idris asked him which places were safe after rain. Amina asked where a traveller could stay for the night. Each question made the drawing more useful. Salim realised that no single person held the complete answer.

As the light faded, Musa walked with them to a safe place for the night. The travellers thanked him and shared their evening meal.

When they stopped, Musa gave Hassan a little dry grass for the mules. In return the travellers shared dates and soup. Amina asked Musa whether he had heard news from Aït Saha. He had met a man from the village near the market twelve days earlier. The man said that some houses had stored grain for winter, but other families had almost none. The school children were taking their meals together so that no one would go without food. "Fatima has been making lists," Musa said. "She knows which family needs help first."

The story made the village feel closer to Salim. In his mind, it was no longer a small black name on a page. It was a place where children waited for a teacher, and where people counted their last sacks of grain. He checked the ropes again

before sleeping. If the food arrived wet or spilled on the road, the long journey would mean little.

Salim wrote in his notebook: THE OLD PATH. THREE CIRCLES. He looked at his father's writing on the map and wondered why the circles mattered.

That night the wind became stronger. Salim heard it move around the stone walls. He thought about the people waiting for the supplies. There were still five days to go, and he began to understand how far away the village really was.

Before going to sleep, Salim opened the notebook under the shelter's low roof. He wrote three things that had changed his plans: the narrow path, Musa's warning about the bridge, and the story of the three stones. He drew a new line beside his father's line. It was not as straight, but it followed the places they had actually walked.

Amina saw him working. "Are you making a better map?" she asked. "I am making a more honest one," he answered. She nodded. "That is a good beginning." Outside, the wind moved around the stones like running water. Salim put his pencil down and listened to the animals breathing. Tomorrow, he thought, they would learn whether the clouds above the high pass were friendly or not.

DAY THREE

Rain on the Pass

The rain began on the third morning. At first it was light, but by noon water was running down every path. Idris decided that they should stop under a large rock until the heavy rain passed.

The clouds were so low that Salim could not see the top of the nearest mountain. The path was brown and soft beneath his feet. Small streams crossed it in places where there had been dry stones the day before. Hassan had wrapped the barley sacks in thick cloth, but the rain still found its way through small openings. Every hour they stopped to check the loads. Progress was slow, and everyone had wet shoes.

Amina wanted to keep moving while the rain was light. Idris watched the water coming down the hill and shook his head. "The weather may change quickly here," he said. "A path that is safe at breakfast can be dangerous after lunch." Salim wanted to ask how long they might wait. Then he saw a brown wave run across the road in front of them. The guide had been right. The group moved back to a shelf of rock above the water.

The travellers pulled their cloaks around them. The mules stood close together with their heads low. Amina checked the bags of barley. She found that one cover was open, so she tied it again.

"We must keep the food dry," she said. "The village cannot use ruined grain."

Salim took the letter from his coat to make sure it was safe. The seal was still in place. Then he reached for his father's map. His bag was wet, and one corner of the paper was soft. When he opened it, a strong wind caught the paper.

"Hold it!" Amina shouted.

Salim caught one end, but the other end tore away. A small piece flew over the rocks and disappeared in the rain. The missing piece showed the old path near the river.

Salim went one step after the lost piece, but Idris caught his arm. "Stop," the guide said. "The ground is wet and the wind is strong. A piece of paper is not worth a fall." Salim looked down. Water had cut a little channel through the stones beside his foot. The paper was already out of sight. He felt foolish, not

because he had dropped the map, but because he had almost forgotten the danger around him.

Amina took the part of the map that remained and laid it between two dry pieces of cloth. Hassan helped her cover it. They waited until Salim could hold his hands still. "We have lost some information," she said. "We have not lost the road." Idris agreed. He asked each traveller to describe the last clear place they remembered. Hassan spoke about a wide stone. Amina remembered a group of tall trees. Salim drew both in his notebook. Their memories began to make a new map.

"I am sorry," Salim said. He held the torn map with both hands. "Now we cannot see the last part."

Idris looked at the paper without anger. "We still have our eyes. We still have people who know these mountains. The map was useful, but it was not the road itself."

They waited until the rain became lighter. Then Idris led them down toward a small village of low stone houses. Water covered the street, and children watched from the doors.



The village appeared slowly through the rain. First they saw a low wall. Then they heard a dog, and finally a row of houses with small windows. A child showed them the way to a sheltered yard. Salim did not enter any house before Idris had spoken to the family who lived there. They needed a place to keep the bags dry, but they did not wish to take space from people without asking.

Lalla Zohra opened her door before they could explain very much. She looked at the wet travellers and pointed to the fire. "You can talk when you are warm," she said. Her family moved a bench and brought extra cups. Hassan stayed outside until the animals were under cover. Only then did he take off his wet cloak. Salim watched him and felt ashamed that he had been thinking only about the paper in his bag.

At one house, a woman named Lalla Zohra welcomed the travellers. She let them put their wet clothes near a fire. Hassan fed the mules in a covered place beside the house.

When Zohra heard about the torn map, she asked to see the part that remained. Her eyes stopped on the three circles.

"I have seen this sign," she said. "My grandfather used it when he travelled with animals. It means that there is water behind a line of stones. I think he called it the Three Wells Path."

"Do you know where it begins?" Salim asked.

"Not exactly. But there is an old tree above the river. Look for three round stones under it. From there, the path turns east."

Zohra remembered hearing her grandfather speak about an old water route. He had carried wool across the hills when he was a boy. On very dry days, traders looked for three rounded stones under a bent tree. The stones were not a message that everyone could read. They were part of a story told from one traveller to another. "If you follow only the stones, you may still be lost," she warned. "The river can move them. Look for the old tree and the shape of the land as well."

Salim made her repeat the directions slowly. He wrote down the place of the tree, the side of the river, and the turn toward the east. He asked whether there were dangerous places nearby. Zohra pointed to the map and named a narrow valley where loose stones fell after heavy rain. He drew a warning mark beside it. Then she gave him a dry thread and told him to tie his father's torn map inside a stronger cloth cover. He thanked her for the gift. It was small, but it made the rest of his work possible.

Salim thanked her. He was pleased to have a new clue, but he still felt bad about the map.

Later, while everyone rested, Amina sat beside him. "You tried to save the paper," she said. "The wind was too strong. We did not lose the whole map."

"My father kept it for years," Salim answered. "I wanted to bring it home without a mark."

"Then bring home the story of how it helped people," Amina said. "That may matter more."

"When I was young," Amina said, "my mother sent me to find a spring with an empty jug. I followed the wrong footpath and came home with no water. I was angry with myself. The next morning she went with me and showed me the right

stones. She did not call me foolish. She said that mistakes can teach us where to look."

Salim stared at his notebook. The words were simple, but he understood them. The torn paper was still part of his father's work. It was not the whole of it. His father had taught him to notice roads, hills, rivers and people. None of those lessons had been carried away by the wind. He asked Amina to tell him again about the trees near the spring. This time he listened carefully and made a small drawing beside his notes.

The travellers slept indoors that night. Outside, water ran through the village street. Salim placed the letter and the torn map near his bed. Before he closed his eyes, he drew three circles in his notebook. He would not forget that sign.

Before sleep, Zohra's daughter brought a small oil lamp. Salim placed the letter beside it and checked the red seal without opening the paper. There were people who might need that letter more than he needed a perfect map. He put the letter back in its dry cloth cover.

Idris sat beside the fire and studied the sky through the doorway. "The clouds are going east," he said. "We may have a clear morning." Hassan counted the supplies again, and Amina helped Zohra put bowls on a shelf. For the first time that day, Salim felt calm. The rain had changed their route, but it had also brought them to someone who remembered the old signs. He wrote her name beside the three circles: LALLA ZOHRA. Then he closed the book.

DAY FOUR

Three Stones by the River

On the fourth morning the clouds were high and pale. The rain had stopped, but the river was still full. Idris told the group that the main crossing was not safe. They would look for the old path instead.

The first hour was difficult because the hills were still wet. Every stone seemed to have a small pool beside it. Idris asked the group to stay above the river until the water went down. Salim was pleased to see blue sky, but he had learned not to believe that a clear morning meant an easy road. He kept his father's map wrapped in cloth and used the notebook for new marks.

Before leaving the village, they thanked Zohra for the warm room. She would not accept money for the shelter. "When travellers help one another, the roads stay open," she said. Amina gave her a little salt from their own food bag. It was not a large gift, but Zohra smiled. Salim wrote another note: People know what the map cannot show. The words seemed worth keeping.

Zohra's son walked with them to the last house of the village. He pointed to a hill with one tall tree. "The old tree is there," he said. "My mother says there are many loose rocks. Walk carefully."

The path climbed between fields of grass and dark stone. Salim kept the torn map in his hand, away from the wind. Amina walked first, looking for the tree. Idris checked the ground after every turn.

Near noon they found it. The tree was old and bent, but it was still alive. Under it lay three round stones in a straight line. They were almost hidden by grass.

"Three circles," Salim said. "My father put them on the map."

He moved the grass and saw a little mark on the side of one stone. It looked like a short arrow. Amina found another arrow on a rock farther up the hill.

The arrow was very small. A person walking quickly might never have seen it. Salim brushed away loose earth but did not move the stone. He called Idris and Amina over to look. Idris asked which direction the mark pointed. "East," Salim said. "But the river is to the west." Amina looked up the slope. "Perhaps the mark sends us away from the water before the path comes back to it," she said.

They tested the idea slowly. Idris walked a short distance ahead without the animals. He found another stone with a similar mark. Then he found a place

where the ground became firmer and the trees grew closer together. Only after he came back did Hassan bring the mules forward. Salim drew the two marks, one after the other, in his notebook. He no longer wanted to make a neat straight line simply because it looked beautiful on paper. The real path turned where the land made it turn.

"The old travellers left signs," she said. "They wanted the next traveller to find the way."

The group followed the marks. The path was not wide, but the ground felt firm. After an hour they came to a small spring behind a wall of stone. Clean water came out slowly and filled a shallow pool.

Hassan smiled. "Now we can give the animals a proper rest."



They filled their water bags and sat beside the spring. Salim drew the place in his notebook. He added the tree, the three stones and the direction of the next mark.

The water ran out from beneath two dark rocks. It was clear, and the earth around it was cool. Hassan let the animals rest before giving them water a little at a time. Amina filled their bags. She also looked carefully at the place where the water began. "If many people come here, they must keep it clean," she said. "A spring can help a whole valley, but it can also be damaged by careless hands."

Salim drew the bent tree, three stones and spring on a new page. He added a small mark for the safe place to stand with the animals. Idris watched him and said, "What will a person think if your drawing is wrong?" Salim looked at the page again. He had placed the spring too close to a steep drop. He rubbed out the line and drew it where it belonged. "Then they may walk into danger," he answered. Idris nodded. "That is why you must check your work."

"We could give this drawing to other travellers," he said.

"Yes," Idris answered. "But first we must be sure that the road is safe all the way. A useful map tells the truth."

In the afternoon they met two men carrying wood from the hills. One man was called Rachid. When he heard the name Aït Saha, he looked concerned.

At first the two wood carriers stood back from the caravan. They had seen strangers on the road before and did not know what the sacks held. Amina explained that people in Fez had given grain for Aït Saha. The men looked at one another. Rachid came closer and asked the name of the teacher who wrote the letter. "Fatima," Salim said. "She sent it to my uncle Omar." Rachid opened his mouth in surprise. "Fatima is my sister," he replied. "I have been worrying about her since the river rose."

His companion had to return with the wood, but Rachid asked to join the caravan. He had been travelling between valleys since he was a boy. He knew where a small wall gave shelter from the wind and where fallen stones blocked the lower paths. "I cannot promise that every part of the road is safe," he said. "I can tell you what I know and help you check the rest." Idris agreed. Salim noticed how the two men spoke. Neither tried to sound more certain than he was.

"The village has little grain," Rachid said. "My sister lives there. She sent a message last week. They are waiting for a caravan from Fez."

"We are that caravan," Amina said.

Rachid looked at the six bags of barley and nodded. "Then I will help. I know where the old path goes next. It does not cross the broken bridge."

The new companion led them toward a row of low hills. The evening light made long shadows on the path. For the first time since the rain, Salim felt sure they were going in the right direction.

Rachid explained that Aït Saha had not always been far from the markets. Years ago, families carried wool and grain along the old path every month. Then a newer road opened beside the river. It was easier and wider, and most people stopped using the mountain track. The trees grew across some parts, and younger travellers forgot the signs. "Now the bridge is gone," Rachid said, "and we need the old road again."

Salim listened carefully. He had thought that a forgotten path was a useless path. But the people who built it had known the mountains well. He asked Rachid where the road turned after the spring. Rachid drew the line with his finger on the earth. The drawing did not agree exactly with Salim's map. Salim asked questions until he understood why. The road climbed to avoid a deep ravine. It was longer, but safer for animals carrying heavy bags.

At night they rested in a dry hollow between the rocks. Rachid spoke about his sister and the village school. Salim listened. The people waiting at the end of the road were no longer strangers in his mind.

After dinner, the travellers sat near the dry wall. Rachid spoke about his sister. Fatima taught children letters and numbers in a small room with a stone floor. She also wrote messages for older villagers who could not read. During the last flood, she had helped move blankets to houses on higher ground. "She will be glad to hear that you are coming," he said. "She will be even happier when she sees the food."

Salim shared a memory of his father. When he was a boy, his father had taken him to a high place above Fez and asked him to draw the streets. Salim drew many rooftops, but he forgot the people below. His father laughed and said, "A town is more than houses." Now Salim understood a little more. He added Rachid's name to the page beside the old path. Then he counted four small marks for the days behind them and three for the days ahead.

Four days were gone. Three days remained.

DAY FIVE

The Empty Water Bag

Day five was warm and dry. The path ran above a long valley, and the mountains stood like dark walls on both sides. Rachid told the travellers that there was no village until the following evening. They would have to carry enough water.

In the morning Salim's lips were dry before he took his first drink. The night had been warmer than expected, and the sun rose into a clear sky. The mountains looked gentle from far away, but the path was covered with sharp stones. Rachid said that travellers had to choose their resting places carefully in this part of the valley. There were no houses close to the main road. They could not count on meeting anyone with spare water.

Hassan gave each person a cup before they left. He saved enough for the animals and put the water bags in the shade while he packed. "A mule cannot tell us when it has had too little water," he said. "We must watch its steps and breathing." Salim wanted to offer the animals all his own water, but Hassan explained that tired people could also make dangerous mistakes. They needed a fair plan for everyone.

Hassan checked the water bags after breakfast. One was empty. A loose knot had allowed the water to escape during the night. He held the bag up, and everyone could see the dark wet mark on the ground.

"We have less water than I thought," he said.

Nobody blamed Hassan for the empty bag. He had tied it carefully the evening before, and the rope had rubbed against a rough stone during the night. Idris asked them to think about what they knew, not what they feared. They still had two full bags and the small amount left in a third. They had enough to travel for some hours, but not enough to cross the next long dry part without finding more water.

Amina spread a cloth on the ground and placed three stones on it. Each stone stood for one of the remaining water bags. She moved the stones as they discussed the route. If they went back to the spring, they would lose most of the day. If they went down toward the trees, they might find water sooner, but the climb back would be hard. Rachid knew the place from his childhood. "We can try the trees," he said, "but we must stop before the mules are tired." Idris agreed to that rule.

Salim remembered the spring from the day before. "Can we go back?" he asked.

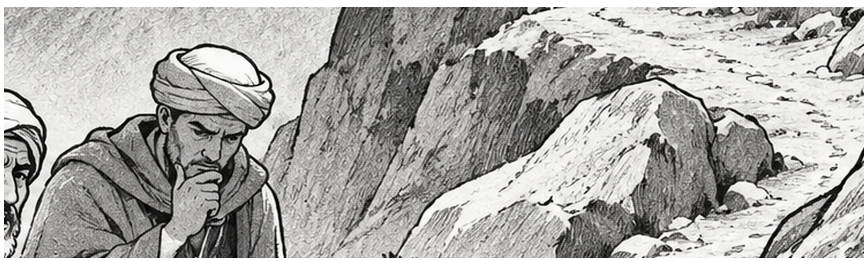
"We could," Idris said, "but that would cost most of the day. There may be a better way."

Rachid pointed to a line of trees far below. "There is usually water where those trees grow. I used to take my father's animals there."

The path down was steep. It would be easy for a mule to slip. Idris asked everyone to walk without hurrying. They left the main track and followed the small trees into a sheltered valley.

The descent took longer than it appeared from above. Idris walked first to test each turn, and Hassan brought the animals behind him. Salim carried a small water bag so that the mules had less weight on the steep path. Amina watched the slope for falling stones. Twice they stopped and listened before moving again.

Near the bottom the trees became taller. Their leaves were still green although the rest of the valley looked dry. Salim could smell damp earth. "There must be water," he whispered. Rachid told him not to hurry. In some places, water ran below the stones and could not be reached easily. They followed the soft ground until they heard a quiet sound beneath a low bank. Amina knelt to listen. It sounded like someone pouring water into a bowl.



At first they saw only dry stones. Then Amina heard a sound under the leaves. Water was running between two rocks. It was not a large stream, but there was enough for the animals and the travellers.

"You were right," Salim told Rachid.

Rachid shook his head. "I remembered a place. We still had to find it."

While they rested, Salim looked inside one of the barley bags. He noticed a small tear near the bottom. A few grains had fallen onto the ground. He called Hassan and helped him mend it with a needle and thick thread.

When the water bags were full, Salim took the damaged barley sack to a flat rock. Hassan showed him how to turn its edge inward before sewing. The work was

slow. Salim's first stitches were uneven, and he had to begin again. "This is why we inspect the bags every night," Hassan said. "A small hole becomes a large one if we ignore it." Salim thought about the torn corner of the old map. He understood the lesson.

Amina saved the few grains that had fallen on a clean cloth. She put them back in the sack rather than leaving them for the birds. She did not do it because the amount was large. She did it because the grain was meant for people who needed it. Salim wrote down the loss in his notebook. He wanted Fatima to know that the group had cared for what the families of Fez had given.

"The bags have travelled a long way," Hassan said. "We must check them every day."

They climbed back to the main path after lunch. The climb was slow, and everyone was tired. Near sunset they came to a place where two paths met. One went across a high ridge. The other entered a dark valley.

"Which one?" Salim asked.

Idris looked at the sky. "There will be wind on the ridge tonight. The valley may be better, but I cannot see all of it."

Salim studied his notebook. The three arrows from the old path pointed toward the valley. He wanted to choose quickly, but he remembered the frightened mule on day two.

The two paths looked almost the same from where Salim stood. He could see a high ridge to the left, open to the wind, and a narrow valley to the right. He remembered how he had wanted to hurry when Noura stopped near the cliff. Now he asked Idris what they should check before making a choice. "We need water, shelter, and a way for the animals," Idris answered. "The shortest road is not useful if we cannot complete it."

Rachid walked a little way into the valley and returned. He had found the old wall he remembered. It stood beside a field that had not been used for many years. The place was dry, but the stones were strong enough to stop the worst wind. Salim compared this news with his notebook. The new marks made sense. The route was not simply a line on paper; it was a chain of places where people and animals could rest safely.

"We should ask Rachid," he said. "He knows this part of the mountains."

Rachid smiled. "The valley is the old road. There is a safe sleeping place beyond the next hill."

They walked another hour and found a low stone wall beside a dry field. They made a small fire and rested. Salim looked at the stars above the ridge.

That night Idris asked everyone to name one thing they had learned. Hassan said that a rope should be checked even when it looked strong. Amina said that people should listen to quiet sounds as well as loud ones. Rachid said old paths still carried useful memories. Salim thought for a long time before he spoke. "I used to believe the person with the map should always know the answer," he said. "Now I think the person with the map should ask good questions."

The others smiled. Amina told him to write that sentence down. He did. Then he made a drawing of the water bags and the valley wall. The moon rose above the ridge, but the camp stayed dark and quiet. Far away, beyond a line of black hills, people were waiting for the six sacks of barley. There were only two days left.

He understood something new. A good leader did not always have the answer. Sometimes a good leader knew whom to ask.

DAY SIX

The Broken Crossing

Early on day six, the travellers could see a high white mountain in the distance. Rachid said that Aït Saha stood on the other side of the next valley. The journey was almost over, but a deep river lay between them and the village.

Everyone was tired after five days on the road. Salim could see that Hassan's hands were rough from the ropes. Amina had worn a little hole in one shoe. Idris's voice was calm, but he walked more slowly when the ground was steep. Even Rachid, who knew these valleys, stopped to rest more often. Salim felt a strong wish to finish quickly. Then he remembered the reason for the journey. Arriving with broken boxes or injured animals would not help anyone.

Before they left camp, he checked the supplies without being asked. All six sacks were still there. The cloth boxes remained dry. The red seal on the letter was unbroken. He showed Idris the new map he had drawn. "Good work," the guide said, "but we must check the final crossing before you call this road safe."

They reached the river near midday. The bridge had lost several large stones, and part of the path to it was gone. Water moved quickly between the rocks. Hassan stopped the mules well away from the edge.

The broken bridge made a sad picture. Some of its stones lay far below in the water. A narrow part of the road had disappeared beside the bank. Salim imagined children standing here on an ordinary school day, waiting to cross to the fields on the other side. He had not understood the full problem when he read Fatima's letter in Fez. It was not only the grain that could not reach Aït Saha. People could not travel safely to the market or visit their family in the next valley.

Amina stood well back from the edge and studied the old stonework. "The river has more power than we think," she said. Idris told everyone not to walk on the damaged part, even for a better view. Hassan tied the animals to a tree in a safe place. Salim took out his notebook and marked the bridge with a large cross, then wrote: DO NOT USE THIS CROSSING.

"We cannot use this crossing," Idris said.

Salim looked across the river. On the far side he saw a faint path climbing the hill. It seemed close enough to touch, but there was no safe way to reach it here.

"We came this far," Salim said. "There must be another way."

Rachid pointed downstream. "The old crossing is below that bend. It is longer, but the water is usually lower there."

They followed him. After half an hour they found a wide, shallow place where the river ran over flat stones. The water was still strong. Idris watched it carefully and asked Hassan to keep the mules back while he and Rachid examined the banks.

They did not enter the water. Instead they walked farther along the shore. Behind a small hill they found a narrow stone path leading to an older bridge.

The older bridge was almost hidden by small trees. From the lower path it looked like part of the hillside. Salim might have walked past it without noticing the carefully placed stones. Amina found steps that led down to a firm bank, and Rachid pointed out where the old path continued on the other side. Idris did not let anyone cross at once. First he checked the ground near the bridge and looked for stones that had moved after the rain.



The travellers made a simple plan. Two people would cross on foot without heavy loads, carrying only a rope. If the ground felt unsafe, they would turn back. Hassan would then lead the lightest animal, and Salim would stay behind with the remaining bags. Everyone understood the plan before the first person moved. There was no shouting and no pushing.

It had no high walls, but its strong centre was still standing. Idris examined the stones from both ends and decided that the group should first test the way without the animals.

Amina and Rachid crossed on foot. They reached the other bank and called that the path was firm. Hassan then led the lightest mule across slowly. It reached the far side without trouble. The other animals followed, one at a time.

Salim waited on the near bank and watched Amina's feet. She moved slowly, finding the firm places before taking the next step. Rachid stayed near her and carried the rope. When they reached the other side, they did not wave for the

animals immediately. They checked the path that went away from the bridge as well. Then they called for Hassan.

Noura was the first mule to cross. She did not like the sound of water under the stones. Hassan spoke to her quietly, just as he had done on the narrow path on the second day. Salim remembered how he had wanted to pull her forward. This time he waited without moving. Noura crossed, then Barak, then the third mule. The loads stayed balanced. On the far bank, Hassan gave the animals time to rest. The caravan had passed another danger without losing a single bag.

Only when everyone was safe did Salim breathe easily.

"A broken bridge sent us to a better crossing," Amina said.

"Not a better crossing for everyone," Idris answered. "We must tell the village where it is and which stones need repair. People should not have to guess."

They spent the afternoon climbing toward the last ridge. At the top, the wind was cold and the clouds were dark again. Salim could see a few lights far away, low in the valley.

The last climb was the steepest of the week. Salim's legs hurt, and his notebook felt heavy in his bag. Every time the group reached what looked like the top, another small hill appeared. Idris kept them together. He said that people often make mistakes when they think the journey is nearly finished.

At the top, they saw smoke rising from a line of distant roofs. Rachid stopped walking. For a moment he did not speak. "My sister lives there," he said at last. "I can see the place where she works." His face looked different: tired, relieved, and afraid all at once. Salim understood that Rachid had not only been guiding strangers. He had been trying to reach someone he loved. The village seemed close, but the path down was still difficult.

"Is that Aït Saha?" he asked.

"Yes," Rachid said. "Those are the houses near the spring."

Salim smiled, then looked at the sacks of barley. All six were still with them. The cloth was dry, and the sealed letter was safe.

But they could not reach the village that evening. The road down was covered with loose stone, and daylight was almost gone. Idris would not take the animals through that place in the dark.

They slept beside a large rock above the valley. Salim was disappointed, but he remembered Hassan's words: sometimes going slowly is the fastest way.

They made a small camp beside the rock. Hassan loosened the ropes and let the mules lie down. Amina gave each person a little food, saving the rest for the next morning. Rachid wanted to continue down the hill, but Idris asked him to look at the loose stones in the fading light. "We are one hour from the village," the guide said, "and we may be ten steps from a fall. Let us arrive when we can see the road." Rachid lowered his head and agreed.

Salim opened his notebook one last time before sleep. He drew the broken bridge, the older crossing and the place where the group had stopped. He added a warning about the steep path below the ridge. He had begun the journey trying to protect an old piece of paper. Now he was making a new record so other people could avoid danger. In the cool night he thought about the children of Aït Saha and hoped he would hear their voices tomorrow.

In the night he dreamed of his father's old map. This time the three circles were not only marks on paper. They were a tree, three stones and a spring in the mountains. The road had become real.

DAY SEVEN

The Village Beyond the Hills

The seventh morning was bright. The travellers rose early and packed the last of their food. Below them, Aït Saha lay beside a narrow stream. The houses were made of stone and earth, and smoke came from their roofs.

Salim looked down at the roofs below. Thin lines of smoke moved into the morning sky. Somewhere a rooster called, and the sound came up the valley like a message. He could hardly believe that the village was so close. He had imagined the arrival many times, but now he felt nervous. The letter had travelled seven days under his clothes. Would Fatima be waiting? Would the grain be enough?

Idris joined him. "You are thinking about the last part," he said. Salim nodded. "I am afraid we may have arrived too late." Idris pointed toward the smoke. "People are making breakfast. They have carried on without us. We will help them do it tomorrow and the day after. Do not make a story of failure before you have spoken to anyone." Salim smiled and helped him prepare the animals for the final descent.

They followed the last path down. At the first house, a child saw the mules and ran into the village. Soon several people came out to meet the caravan. A woman in a blue shawl hurried toward Rachid.

"My brother!" she cried. "You came back!"

Rachid smiled and embraced her. "I found the people from Fez," he said. "And they brought what you need."

The woman was his sister, Fatima. She helped at the village school and wrote letters for people who could not write. She had sent the request to Omar in Fez after the river damaged the bridge.

An older man named Yacoub welcomed Salim, Amina, Idris and Hassan. He counted the six bags of barley and the two boxes of cloth. Nothing was missing.

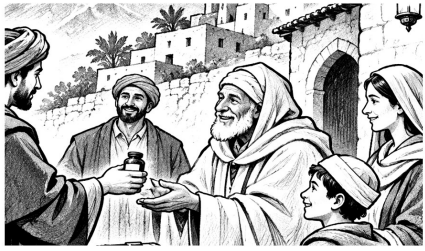
Yacoub led the travellers to the dry room beside the school. Villagers opened the sacks only after Hassan had placed them on clean boards. Fatima brought a list of households and asked two older children to help count. The sacks were not opened to reward the loudest voices or the strongest people. The grain would be shared according to need. Amina gave Fatima the boxes of cloth, and together they chose warm pieces for children and elderly neighbours.

Salim watched a young boy carry a small bundle to his grandmother. The boy walked slowly because the cloth was almost as large as he was. He thanked Amina, then ran back to help again. Salim thought of the people who had given the grain in Fez. Their gifts had crossed hills and rivers to become real help in these small houses. He wrote that down because he did not want to forget it.

"You have done more than bring food," he said. "You have shown us that the road is still open."

Salim gave Fatima the sealed letter. She read it beside the school door and then showed it to the older villagers. Omar had promised to send more supplies if the village could tell him which road was safe. He also asked them to send a map of the new crossing.

"We found one," Salim said. He opened his notebook and showed the three stones, the hidden spring and the old bridge. Idris explained which parts of the path needed repairs.



Fatima read Omar's letter aloud so everyone could hear the same message. It said that people in Fez wished to help again, but they needed clear news about the road. More supplies could be sent only when travellers knew where they could cross safely. Fatima looked at Salim's notebook. "Your notes may be as important as the food," she said.

The villagers gathered around a low table. Idris explained the broken bridge and the danger beside it. Rachid showed the older crossing on the map. Hassan marked the narrow parts where the mules had needed help. Amina showed them where a spring lay hidden below the dry trees. Salim wrote each point in clear words. He did not say the old road was easy. He said that it could be used carefully, and that the river must be checked after heavy rain.

Fatima looked closely at the first drawing. "My grandfather spoke of these stones," she said. "He said people once left marks so that strangers could find water. Later, the road was forgotten."

"My father drew the same marks," Salim answered. "I thought they were only little circles."

"They were a way to help someone he would never meet," Fatima said.

That afternoon the villagers shared bread and soup with the travellers. Amina helped Fatima carry cloth to families who needed it. Hassan gave the mules a long rest. Idris walked with Yacoub to look at the lower crossing from a safe distance.

After the meal, Fatima opened the schoolroom. There were low benches and a small blackboard. Salim saw children copying letters in their notebooks. One girl asked why he carried so many drawings. "They are maps," he answered. "They help people find places." She wanted to know whether the road to Fez was a straight line. Salim laughed. "No. It turns many times because of the mountains." He drew a hill, a river and a bridge, then asked the children to tell him which path looked safest.

The children had different ideas. One boy chose the short road by the river. A girl chose the longer line above the water. Fatima asked them to explain their answers. Salim listened and saw the value of her work. She was teaching children not only to read words, but also to ask questions and give reasons. He understood why the village needed her so much.

Salim sat in the school with his notebook. He drew a clean map from the pages he had written during the journey. He did not copy the old map without thinking. He added the places they had visited and wrote short notes beside the difficult parts.

At the bottom he wrote: THE OLD ROAD IS NOT GONE. ASK THE PEOPLE WHO KNOW IT.

Before evening, Fatima brought him a small piece of paper. On it she had written the names of the people who helped the caravan: Musa, Zohra, Rachid, Amina, Idris and Hassan.

Fatima's list had more names than Salim expected. There was Musa, who had spoken of the old signs; Zohra, who had remembered the tree; and Rachid, who had joined them on the road. There were also Amina, Idris and Hassan, who had done the hard work every day. Salim added each name in small careful letters. Then he left some space at the bottom of the page. "For the people who repair the road," he said. Fatima smiled. "Yes. A road is never the work of only one person."

Yacoub came to the school with two other villagers. They had already begun to plan how to mark the safer crossing and repair a short part of the path. They would not attempt the broken bridge until someone with the right skills could

examine it. Salim showed them the drawings and asked them to correct anything that was wrong. They moved one mark nearer the bend in the river. He was pleased, not upset. The map was better because they had checked it together.

"Please put their names on your map," she said. "The road belongs to everyone who keeps it safe."

Salim did so. He thought of his father in Fez, bending over a map by candlelight, and felt close to him.

The next morning the caravan would begin its journey home. It might take more than seven days, because they would travel carefully. This time Salim knew the old signs, and he knew the names of the people beside the road.

As the sun went down behind the Atlas Mountains, he stood outside the school. The people of Aït Saha were carrying the grain into a dry room. Children laughed in the street, and smoke rose slowly into the cold air.

At supper, Rachid sat with Fatima and told her about the storm. Hassan spoke about Noura on the narrow ridge, and Amina described the three stones under the old tree. They laughed when Salim admitted that he had once thought a good mapmaker should know every answer. "And now?" Fatima asked. "Now I know a good mapmaker must listen," he said.

The children asked whether the travellers would return. Idris said they hoped to come again when the road was safer. Salim promised to send a clear copy of the new map from Fez. Amina said she would speak to people living along the route so they could help watch the crossing after storms. The plans were small, but they belonged to many people. That made them possible. At the door, Fatima thanked Salim for carrying the letter. "I only carried it," he answered. "The whole caravan brought it here."

Seven days earlier he had left Fez with a letter and a map. Now he had brought the letter to its home, and he had found a new road for others to follow.

Glossary

40 useful words from the story, in alphabetical order

Read each word, its meaning, and the example. Return to the story when you need help.

Word	Meaning	Example
animal	a living creature, such as a mule	Hassan checks every animal before the climb.
barley	a grain used as food	The six bags of barley must stay dry.
bridge	a structure carrying a road over a river	Part of the bridge has been damaged.
caravan	a group travelling together with goods	The caravan leaves Fez at sunrise.
cliff	a high, steep wall of rock	The path runs beside a cliff.
cloak	a long piece of clothing worn outside	Amina wears a dark wool cloak.
cloth	material used for making clothes	The travellers carry boxes of warm cloth.
crossing	a place where people can pass over water	Idris checks the older crossing.
damage	to harm or break something	Rain can damage a map or a bridge.
direction	the way in which someone must travel	The stone mark points in one direction.
dry	not wet	They keep the grain dry under thick covers.
edge	the outside part of something	Noura stops near the edge of the path.
flood	water that covers land which is usually dry	A flood has destroyed part of the road.
grain	small seeds used as food	Families in Fez give grain to the village.

Word	Meaning	Example
guide	a person who leads others along a route	Idris is an experienced mountain guide.
hill	land that rises above the area around it	The path goes over another hill.
journey	travel from one place to another	The journey lasts seven days.
knot	a way of joining or fixing a rope	Hassan checks each knot before leaving.
letter	a written message	Salim carries a sealed letter from Fez.
load	the things carried by an animal or person	A heavy load can hurt a mule.
map	a drawing showing places and routes	Salim makes a new map of the old path.
mule	an animal used to carry loads	Three mules carry the food and cloth.
pass	a route between mountains	Rain falls heavily on the high pass.
path	a narrow way for walking or travelling	The path turns away from the river.
ridge	a long, high part of land	Wind makes the ridge dangerous.
river	a large natural flow of water	The river is too high to cross here.
rope	a thick strong string	Hassan uses rope to hold the boxes.
safe	not in danger	They look for a safe place to rest.
seal	a mark that keeps a letter closed	The red seal on the letter is unbroken.
shelter	a place that protects people from weather	The travellers find shelter before dark.
slope	a surface that rises or falls	The steep slope is difficult for mules.
spring	a place where water comes from the ground	The old signs lead to a hidden spring.
steep	rising or falling sharply	The road becomes steep near the ridge.

Word	Meaning	Example
stone	a small piece of rock	Three round stones mark the old way.
stream	a small river	A stream runs between the rocks.
supplies	things needed for work or life	The village waits for supplies.
tear	to pull something into pieces	Strong wind can tear a paper map.
traveller	a person who makes a journey	A traveller asks the guide for help.
valley	low land between hills or mountains	The road goes down into the valley.
village	a small community of houses	Fatima writes letters for the village.

Reading Comprehension

Choose A, B or C. Read all seven days first.

1. Where does Salim work at the start?

   A. At a map shop in Fez | B. At a village school | C. At the river bridge

2. Who writes the request for help?

   A. Amina | B. Fatima | C. Zohra

3. What does the caravan carry to the village?

   A. Barley and warm cloth | B. Tea and lamps | C. Only maps

4. Who looks after the mules?

   A. Rachid | B. Omar | C. Hassan

5. What happens on the narrow mountain road?

   A. One mule becomes frightened | B. A cart breaks | C. They lose the letter

6. What does Musa tell the travellers?

   A. The village is empty | B. An older path may still exist | C. The road is open to cars

7. What happens to the map in the rain?

   A. It burns | B. It is lost completely | C. A piece is torn away

8. Who remembers the signs on the old route?

   A. Lalla Zohra | B. Yacoub | C. Omar

9. What do the three circles help them find?

   A. A town gate | B. Three stones and a spring | C. A shop in Fez

10. Why does Rachid join the caravan?

    A. He wants to sell a mule | B. His sister lives in Aït Saha | C. He is looking for a lost ring

11. What problem do they face on day five?

    A. A water bag is empty | B. The letter is stolen | C. The grain is sold

12. How do they repair the torn grain sack?

    A. With a needle and thread | B. With wet leaves | C. With a wooden box

13. Why can they not use the first bridge?

A. It is too far away | B. The stones and road are damaged | C. There is a gate across it

14. Why do they wait before the final descent?

A. The road is unsafe in the dark | B. They want to visit a market | C. The animals have run away

15. What does Salim add to his final map?

A. Only his own name | B. Only the fastest roads | C. Safe places, warnings and helpers' names

True or False?

Write T for true or F for false.

1. Salim has never travelled far into the mountains before.

2. The travellers carry eight sacks of grain.

3. Idris wants everyone to move quickly on unsafe roads.

4. The first mule is frightened near a cliff.

5. Salim loses the whole of his father's map.

6. Lalla Zohra remembers the meaning of the three signs.

7. Rachid is Fatima's brother.

8. The group crosses the damaged first bridge.

9. Fatima writes letters for people in the village.

10. Salim puts the names of helpers on his new map.

Short Answer Questions

Write two or three complete English sentences for each answer.

1. Why does Salim want to protect his father's map?

2. What does Hassan teach Salim about Noura on the narrow road?

3. How does Lalla Zohra help the caravan?

4. Why are the three stones important?

5. What do the travellers do when one water bag is empty?

6. Why does Idris refuse to use the damaged bridge?

7. What do the villagers do with the grain when it arrives?

8. What is the most important lesson Salim learns about making maps?

Think · Speak · Write

Discuss with a partner. Then write your own ideas.

1. Is a longer safe road better than a shorter dangerous road? Why?

2. Why should Salim listen to people who live in the mountains?

3. How do the travellers share responsibility during the journey?

4. Can an old map still be useful when the land changes?

5. Which day was the most difficult for the caravan? Explain.

6. What makes a person a good leader in a difficult situation?

Writing Task

Write 120–150 words about a journey when somebody helped you solve a problem.

Where were you going? What happened? Who helped? What did you learn? Use past simple and sequence words such as first, then, after that and finally.

Title: _____

Language Practice

Choose the correct past tense or comparative form.

1. Salim ___ the letter inside his coat.
   keep / kept / keeping

2. The travellers ___ three mules.
   has / had / have

3. The narrow path was ___ than the first road.
   dangerous / more dangerous / most dangerous

4. Amina ___ the torn map in dry cloth.
   wrap / wrapped / wrapping

5. They ___ the first broken bridge.
   did not use / not used / do not used

6. Rachid knew a ___ crossing.
   safe / safer / safest

7. The river ___ quickly after the storm.
   rise / rose / rising

8. Salim ___ a new map at the school.
   draw / drew / draws

9. Fatima ___ letters for the villagers.
   writes / written / writing

10. Idris asked them ___ until daylight.
    wait / to wait / waited

Final Test

20 questions: Vocabulary, Grammar and Story. Choose A, B or C.

Part A - Vocabulary

1. A ___ carries goods together with other travellers.
   A. caravan B. shadow C. shelf

2. A ___ is a place where water comes from the ground.
   A. slope B. spring C. seal

3. A ___ is used to hold sacks and boxes in place.
   A. rope B. roof C. gate

4. A high part of land between valleys is a ___.
   A. market B. ridge C. blanket

5. A ___ is a strong animal that can carry a load.
   A. bird B. cat C. mule

6. A ___ is a route over a river.
   A. crossing B. cloak C. letter

7. A large amount of water covering dry land is a ___.
   A. flood B. map C. shelter

8. A ___ is a place to stay safe from bad weather.
   A. bridge B. shelter C. valley

9. A ___ on a letter shows it has not been opened.
   A. seal B. slope C. grain

10. A ___ is a low area between hills.
    A. valley B. ridge C. wall

Part B - Grammar

11. Yesterday the caravan ___ early.
    A. leave B. left C. leaving

12. The guide ___ them to stop.

A. told B. tell C. telling

13. The second road was ___ than the first.

A. safe B. safer C. safest

14. They ___ walk across the damaged bridge.

A. did not B. does not C. were not

15. Salim ___ a new map at the end.

A. make B. made C. making

Part C – Story

16. Who sends the letter from Aït Saha?

A. Fatima B. Musa C. Hassan

17. What does the wind damage?

A. The cloth B. The map C. The bridge

18. Who remembers the three-stone sign?

A. Omar B. Yacoub C. Lalla Zohra

19. What do the travellers find after the first crossing is damaged?

A. An older safer bridge B. A wide new road C. A ship

20. What does Salim write on his final map?

A. Only the prices of grain B. Warnings and helpers' names C. The market opening times

Score: _____ / 20

Answer Key

Check your answers after completing the activities.

Reading Comprehension

1. A 2. B 3. A 4. C 5. A 6. B 7. C 8. A 9. B 10. B 11. A 12. A 13. B 14. A 15. C

True / False

1. T 2. F 3. F 4. T 5. F 6. T 7. T 8. F 9. T 10. T

Language Practice

1. kept

2. had

3. more dangerous

4. wrapped

5. did not use

6. safer

7. rose

8. drew

9. writes

10. to wait

Final Test

1. A 2. B 3. A 4. B 5. C 6. A 7. A 8. B 9. A 10. A 11. B 12. A 13. B 14. A 15. B 16. A 17. B 18. C 19. A 20. B

Short Answers – Sample Ideas

1. His father made it, and Salim wants to protect his work and his memory.

2. A frightened animal needs space, a calm voice, and a balanced load.

3. She gives the travellers shelter and explains the old sign of three stones.

4. They help the group find the forgotten path and a hidden spring.

5. They discuss their choices carefully and find water below the green trees.

6. The first bridge and the road beside it are damaged and unsafe.

7. They count it, keep it dry and share it with families who need it most.

8. He learns to check his work and listen to local knowledge and other travellers.

Discussion and writing activities may have several correct answers.

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Seven Days Across the Atlas

This graded reader includes:

- A gripping adventure story
- Five illustrated chapters
- A glossary of key vocabulary (40 words)
- Comprehension and discussion questions
- A writing task

English Level

A2

Elementary



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